oriented—in fact, building-focused. Dogs, birds and other wildlife are losing their habitats. Dogs are a part of the ecosystem. If they are eliminated from our neighbourhoods, there could be a massive cat problem, like in many western countries.... Street animals without a collar or proven ownership are being caught and put to sleep if not claimed as pets soon. Millions of cats and dogs are being euthanised every year. Is that the kind of society we want to be?" she asks.

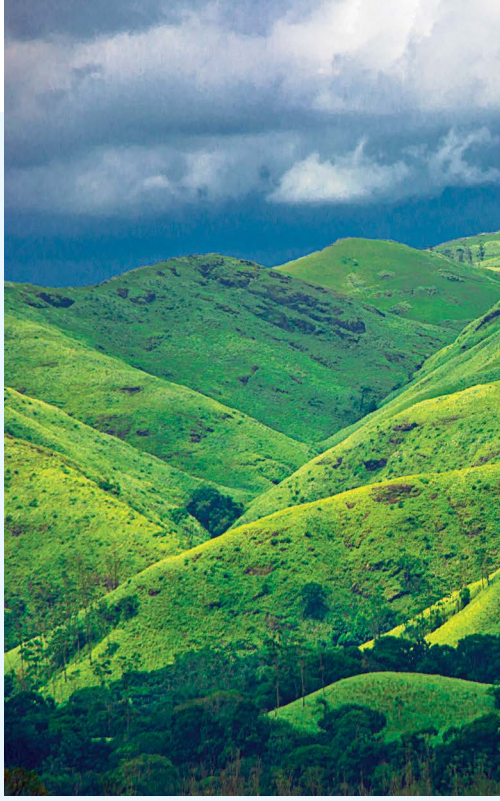
At the same time, there is that other tragic reality that can't be overlooked either: India is the rabies capital of the world, accounting for 36 per cent of rabies deaths globally. In March this year, a five-year-old girl from Surat, Khushi Photographer, contracted the viral disease after an infected dog licked an open wound when she was playing outdoors. That was the second rabies death in Gujarat in just around half a year. Between 2012 and 2020, 142 rabies-related deaths were reported in the state, which has consistently shown a high rate of dog bite incidents—over 20,580 per million population. The persisting threat of rabies, at a time when it has been eliminated in a number of other countries, points to a need for more effective vaccination.

The Centre in 2021 had launched the National Action Plan for Dog-Mediated Rabies Elimination from India by 2030. The programme acts as a guide for states to reduce rabies risk through mass dog vaccinations, pre- and post-exposure prophylaxis and public education, and aims to eradicate the dog-mediated form of the disease from India by 2030. Another piece of law, the Animal Birth Control (Dogs) Rules, 2023, is also in place to control dog numbers across states. Nazareth, however, says the efforts have made little headway. "There's little understanding of how people are bitten. We need access to vaccines, treatment for people, and mass vaccination for dogs. Spreading awareness among vulnerable sections is a mandate under the National Rabies Control Programme. These are things not being done at all," she says. Studies also show the availability of the rabies shot at primary health centres is thin, as also awareness about the disease.

WORRYING STATS

- **Gujarat ranks fifth after Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh and UP in terms of dog bite cases**
- **In Ahmedabad, nearly 7,675 cases of stray canines have been reported so far this year**
- **142 rabies-related deaths were reported in Gujarat from 2012-2020**

Some question dog vaccination/sterilisation as a policy, as also the idea of relocating them. "There's no post-operative care. The dogs die, or return with infections. Relocation is prohibited, but it happens very often. These are territorial animals. Relocation kicks off aggression, which makes an otherwise friendly dog dangerous," says an expert. Clearly, too many loose ends dog India's stray dog crisis. Resolution will require a multi-dimensional approach. It's not the four-legged animals that are the villains in this story—it's the allegedly more intelligent two-legged ones. ■



SHUTTERSTOCK

KERALA

THE SHOLA W

By Jeemon Jacob

Over the past 31 years, retired professor Dr Johnykutty J. Ozhukayil has been trying hard to convince people in Kerala's picturesque hill district Idukki to become more "conscious of nature". He has also led by example, setting up a nature park, Hill 7, on 30 acres of land in Mankuttimedu near Nedumkandam to show that natural shola forests can be regenerated.

Found only in tropical high-altitude (1,500 metres-plus) regions, the sholas are a combination of montane evergreen forests and grasslands that are peculiar to the southern part of the Western Ghats. Mankuttimedu sits about 1,100 metres above sea level and is an entry point to the mountains. Surrounded by seven misty hills, it was once an oasis of shola grasslands. But the area has undergone massive changes, with migrant farmers from the lowlands encroaching on forest land and "clearing the brush" as it were, often with political support.

"It's a pathetic situation. To think that this could happen in highly literate